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Introduction

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Introduction

If anyone knew the Old Covenant law, it was the Apostle Paul. In his early life, as “Saul,” he had been a Pharisee—a devout follower of the Old Covenant of law introduced by Moses.

Circumcised on the eighth day, Saul had been raised and taught in strict obedience to the Law of Moses. As a young man, he had stood by and encouraged those who stoned Stephen—the church’s first martyr. With all the wrath and judgment of the law, Saul had persecuted and killed those who believed in Jesus.

But then, one day on the road to Damascus, Saul was knocked to the ground by a blinding light. From heaven came the words, “Saul, Saul, why do you persecute me?” “Who are you, Lord?” Saul asked. And from heaven came the reply, “I am Jesus, whom you are persecuting” (Acts 9:4-5).

After his Damascus Road experience, Saul, renamed Paul, began living his life, not as governed by the law, but as guided by grace. No longer was he bound by the Ten Commandments and other Old Covenant laws. Faith and love, not legalism, characterized Paul’s new life.

As the first missionary to the gentiles, Paul traveled throughout the Roman Empire preaching Christ. In his letters to communities of new believers, Paul wrote of the life of bondage under the Old Covenant Law and of the life of freedom in the New Covenant love of Christ. Over and over again he commended the believers for their faith and love.

Many Christians today understand the importance of faith. By faith in Jesus as the Son of God, we are reborn into eternal life. We are justified—not through obedience to the law—but by faith. But, faith isn’t complete by itself. Faith gives God access to us so He can pour His love into us. Faith expresses itself through love. God’s love has expression on earth through us. To live the Christian life here on earth as designed, God provided for us to know His love and share it with others.

For most of my life, as a born-again, church-going Christian, I didn’t really understand that God loved me. I wrongly assumed that I needed to work for God’s love. I thought that before God could love me, I needed to show my love for Him by obeying the Ten Commandments and other “good” rules. But, just as it is impossible to receive eternal life through obedience to the law, it is also impossible to love God and others through obedience to the law.

I was deceived. I cannot love God or others on my own. First John 4:19 tells us, “We love because He first loved us.” We can give away only what we have received. For

this reason, we need to be in a constant loving relationship with God.

God values and treasures you beyond measure. You are precious to Him. He has chosen you. He has adopted you into His family. He loves you with an unstoppable, endless love. That love came to rescue you completely—to set you free and to make you whole. Jesus came to give you eternal life in heaven and full life, by His definition, here and now, on earth. God created you to know and experience His love, abide in His love and radiate His love.

Paul's writings overflow with the power and provision of God's unconditional, never-failing love.